8.6.1 Properties of Enzyme

- All are globular proteins.
- They act as catalysts and effective even in small quantity.
- They remain unchanged at the end of the reaction.
- They are highly specific.
- They have an active site where the reaction takes place.
- Enzymes lower activation energy of the reaction they catalyse.



RUBISCO is the abundant protein in the whole biosphere

As molecules react, they become unstable, high energy intermediates. But they are in this transition state only momentarily. Energy is required to raise molecules to this transition state and this minimum energy needed is called the **activation energy**. This could be explained schematically by 'boulder on hillside' model of activation energy (Figure 8.17).

8.6.2 Lock and Key Mechanism of Enzyme

In a enzyme catalysed reaction, the starting substance is the substrate. It is converted to the product. The substrate binds to the specially formed pocket in the enzyme – **the active site**, this is called **lock and key mechanism** of enzyme action. As the enzyme and substrate form a **ES complex**, the substrate is raised in energy to a transition state and then breaks down into products plus unchanged enzyme (Figure 8.18).

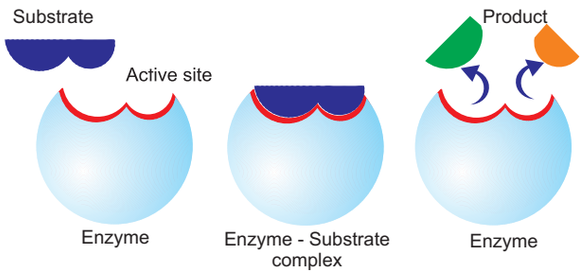
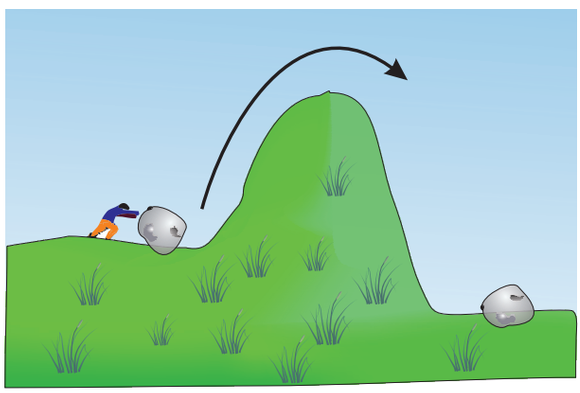


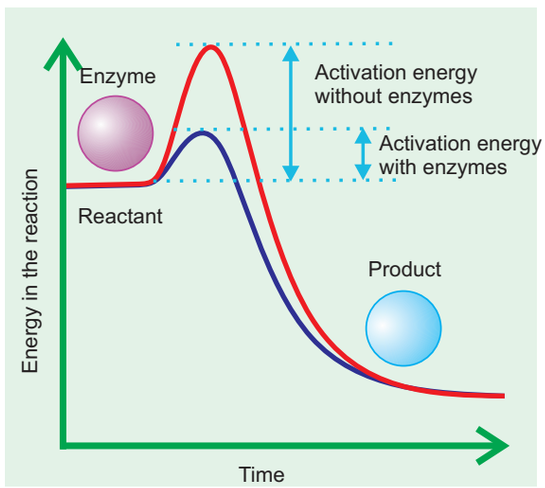
Figure 8.18: Enzyme mechanism

8.6.3 Enzyme Cofactors

Many enzymes require non-protein components called **cofactors** for their efficient activity. Cofactors may vary from simple inorganic ions to complex organic molecules. They are of three types: **inorganic ions, prosthetic groups and coenzymes** (Figure 8.19).

- **Holoenzyme** – active enzyme with its non protein component.
- **Apoenzyme** – the inactive enzyme without its non protein component.





This graph shows the activation energies of a reaction with and without enzymes

Figure 8.17: Activation energy

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